

Exhibit 7

Brent Hoberman and Founders Forum story in WIRED UK - April 2017

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TECH'S
BIGGEST
NAMES
PICK THE
STARS OF
TOMORROW

PREDICTIONS BY
MELINDA GATES
JIMMY WALES
RICHARD BRANSON
KEVIN KELLY
CRAIG VENTER
JOI ITO...
AND 29 MORE

THE SMART LIST

INCLUDING

**SLACK'S
STEWART
BUTTERFIELD**
ON WHY HE'S BETTING
ON EPIBONE'S
NINA TANDON ◀





FOUNDERS EMPIRE

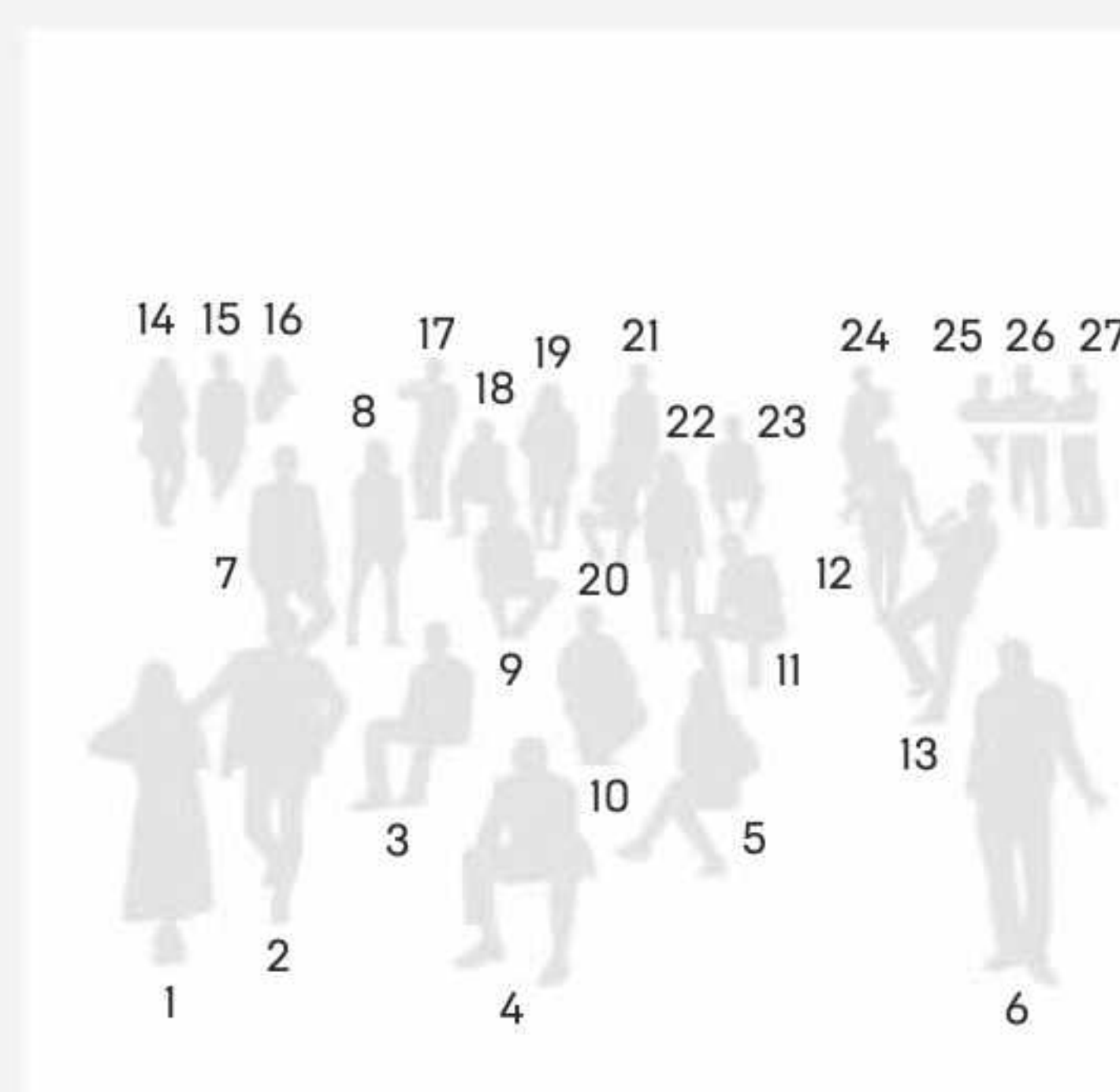
Brent Hoberman has a bold plan to help launch 200 startups by 2021

1. **Poppy Gaye** co-founder, AccelerateHer; head of partnerships and producer, Founders Forum
2. **Brent Hoberman** co-founder and executive chairman, Founders Factory
3. **Pierre-Simon Ntiruhungwa** head, Founders of the Future
4. **Jonathan Goodwin** founder, Lepe Partners
5. **Sandra Steving** head of Innovation, Founders Intelligence
6. **Henry Lane Fox** co-founder and CEO, Founders Factory
7. **Richard Segal** partner, Founders Keepers
8. **Hannah Blake** business development lead, Founders Factory
9. **Greg Kennaugh** CEO, Founders Forum
10. **Frank Meehan** co-founder and CEO, Smart Up
11. **Tim Groot** co-founder and CEO, Grip
12. **Farah Kanji**, head of talent, Founders Factory
13. **Rob Chapman** managing director, Founders Intelligence
14. **Vanessa Gstettenbauer** senior investment manager, Founders Factory
15. **Justus Brown** head of product, Founders Factory
16. **Lubomira Rochet** chief digital officer, L'Oréal Group
17. **Rob Haines** director, Founders Intelligence
18. **Louis Warner** operating officer, Founders Factory
19. **Amy Grimshaw** head of PR and communications, Founders Factory
20. **David Goldberg** co-founder and CEO, Founders Pledge
21. **James Millett** director of marketing, digital and brand, easyJet
22. **Anaïs Benazet** head of events, Founders Forum
23. **Paul Heybourne** head of digital innovation, Aviva
24. **Alan Hudson** chief investment officer, GMG
25. **David Hickson** head of corporate development, Founders Factory
26. **George Northcott** co-founder and head of business development, Founders Factory
27. **Paul Egan** chief technology officer, Founders Factory

BRENT HOBERMAN HAS TRANS-formed the word “founder” into a global project. It all started in 2005 after he sold lastminute.com, the company he formed with Martha Lane Fox. Left with time on his hands, Hoberman teamed up with financier Jonathan Goodwin and organised a get-together for 80 entrepreneurs. It didn’t go well. “The floor wasn’t good,” he says. “We hadn’t invited very successful people. The energy wasn’t good.” But, even so, the idea seemed to have potential.

Fast forward to 2017 and Founders Forum, as the event is known, has become an institution. Held annually in London and repeated in cities across the world, the invite-only gatherings attract the cream of tech and business talent. Reid Hoffman co-hosted in New York in 2012 and Eric Schmidt gave a keynote speech in London in 2014. As the forum has grown, Hoberman and his collaborators, including Martha’s brother Henry Lane Fox, have added to it. Today, Founders Forum’s 3,000-member “private network” supports a sprawling brand comprised of six projects, including the consultancy Founders Intelligence, recruiting agency Founders Keepers and AI-powered entrepreneurial talent-spotter Founders of the Future.

Hoberman even has a nonprofit – Founders Forum For Good. Launched in 2015, the forum’s Founders Pledge asks entrepreneurs to donate at least two per cent of the personal proceeds of any future acquisition to social causes. It has attracted more than 500 pledges, including the founders of Jawbone, DeepMind, Farfetch and Hampton Creek. In September 2016, Mountain View accelerator Y Combinator announced that it would be >



recommending the programme to its members and alumni.

How did the idea take shape? As a sub-section of the main Founders Forum event, where attendees expressed a desire to give back. Now Hoberman is expanding the Forum's most ambitious offshoot: accelerator-turned-incubator Founders Factory. For the 48-year-old, it marks a return to entrepreneurialism, after spending years at PROfounders Capital, the investment firm he set up in 2009. "I decided to leave in mid-2015 to do something really world-class," he recalls, sitting in the glass-fronted meeting room of his soon-to-be-vacated Kensington offices. (In January, the company's 60 staff moved down the road to the *Daily Mail* and General Trust-owned Northcliffe House.) Hoberman is gravelly voiced and gossipy, with tanned skin dark against his trademark white shirt. "I didn't want to go and work for another fund," he continues. "I don't want to feel like an employee, whether that's right or not. And I like building something."

What Hoberman is building is a startup programme backed by A-list corporate partners including L'Oréal, Aviva, easyJet and the Guardian Media Group (GMG). Early-stage companies that get into its six-month programme – the acceptance rate is one per cent – are given targeted mentoring, office space and contacts, plus £30,000 in seed capital. In return, they have to give a three to ten per cent stake to the accelerator – and, in turn, its corporate shareholders.

For Hoberman, this alliance of disrupters and incumbents solves the so-called "innovator's dilemma" – according to which big, established companies are bound to be overtaken by younger, faster competitors. "I was asking myself if corporates could innovate," he says. "I knew it was hard to do so for companies' boards, with things such as consensus management, conflicting priorities and so on. That was the genesis of the Founders Factory." It's also a way of leveraging Europe's competitive advantage. As Hoberman, who sits on the board of *The Economist* and TalkTalk, among others, puts it: "What's Europe got that's world-class? Corporates. Silicon Valley has fewer that aren't tech."

Each of Founders Factory's corporate backers invests in startups in its field – L'Oréal funds health and wellness firms,

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whereas GMG focuses on media ventures. "It's like free R&D for corporations," Hoberman says. But isn't it potentially damaging? What if a media startup, for example, builds a rival to *The Guardian*? "We'd love to do it and *The Guardian* would support it," he insists. Where others might see tension, Hoberman sees a win-win. "We help entrepreneurs and the side effect is that we are helping corporates, too."

Not everybody agrees. "In general, accelerators' track records are chequered," says John Mullins, professor of entrepreneurship at London Business School. "It is very hard to build a successful entrepreneurial venture. Incubators or accelerators don't seem to be better than entrepreneurs working on their own." Neither, he says, are they particularly profitable for corporate backers – who often pressure accelerators to spend their money, resulting in investments in less-than-stellar startups. Still, Mullins admits, being part of a galaxy of interconnected ventures might give Founders Factory a leg-up over its competitors. "Another key difference is the people who are running it," he adds. "They can rightly claim to give good entrepreneurial advice, unlike many others."

Hoberman predicts that by 2021, Founders Factory will have launched 200 startups. It's already five per cent of the way there: since making its debut in 2015, it has helped launch 11 new companies, including data-visualisation studio Flourish and *FitWell*, Turkey's number-one fitness app. Now Hoberman is building the next piece of his jigsaw – a European-focused seed fund, with Skype co-founder Niklas Zennström's Atomico named as the first investor. There's just one problem: the name Founders Fund already belongs to US venture capitalist Peter Thiel. So Hoberman has gone back to the beginning and has named his new fund Firstminute Capital. **Gian Volpicelli and Rowland Manthorpe** *foundersfactory.com*

FOUNDERS FORUM TIMELINE

2005	>	2005	>	2011	>	2013	>	2013
LastMinute sold; Brent Hoberman departs		Entrepreneurs attend first Founders Forum		Founders Forum goes international		First Forum For Good event takes place		Founders Intelligence consultancy opens
Hoberman sets up FirstMinute venture fund		AI talent spotter Founders of the Future launches		Founders Factory launches		Forum For Good becomes Founders Pledge		Founders Keepers recruitment agency opens
2017	<	2016	<	2015	<	2015	<	2014

PHOTOGRAPHY (PREVIOUS PAGE): NICK WILSON. SHOT AT THE DESIGN MUSEUM, LONDON